

Research Statement

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I am an applied microeconomist working at the intersection of labor economics, political economy, economic history and development economics. My research examines how institutions shape the creation and distribution of economic opportunities, and how these opportunities affect economic development and social outcomes. I study these questions in both contemporary and historical settings, combining administrative data with new datasets constructed by digitizing archival sources and using modern empirical tools.

My current research is organized around three related topics: (i) the role of state actors in shaping local economic opportunities; (ii) local government and labor market responses to economic shocks; and (iii) citizens' responses to institutional change.

I. State Actors and Local Economic Outcomes.

Politicians and bureaucrats play a central role in shaping economic outcomes. Political leaders and representation affect public policy and resource allocation (Jones and Olken, 2005; Chattopadhyay and Duflo, 2004), while bureaucratic quality matters for state capacity and development (Besley and Persson, 2009). My research examines these forces at the *local level*, focusing on their effects on economic opportunities and development.

In my job market paper, *“Fathers in Office, Sons in Jobs: Intergenerational Returns to Local Political Office”*, I ask whether holding local political office generates lasting economic advantages for officials' adult children and whether meritocratic civil-service reform can limit these advantages. This question matters because the vast majority of political offices are local, and political influence over local hiring can directly shape the distribution of opportunity within local labor markets. I construct a new dataset by digitizing rosters of township, village, and city officials in early twentieth-century Ohio, linking officials to the full-count U.S. census, and tracing their children from the 1900 to the 1940 Census. Using a matched difference-in-differences design, I compare officials' children with observationally similar non-officials' children before and after fathers enter office. I complement this design with comparisons based on the timing of office entry and between marginal winning and losing candidates.

I find that fathers' entry into local office increases adult sons' occupational income and white-collar employment, with gains persisting for decades. By 1940, officials' sons earn about 13 percent more than their matched counterparts. Effects for daughters are more limited during this period of low female labor force participation. The occupational gains for officials' sons operate through better access to both public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar jobs, with public-sector effects larger where public hiring is less institutionally constrained. Exploiting the staggered adoption of merit-based civil-service reform across Ohio cities, I find that reform curbing discretionary public hiring does not eliminate the intergenerational advantage of officeholding. Instead, private-sector white-collar gains become larger when fathers enter office under civil service, suggesting that institutional constraints

redirect rather than eliminate political advantage. Finally, I find suggestive evidence that townships with a higher share of officials' sons among public employees have greater local income inequality, pointing to broader distributional costs of intergenerational political advantage.

My ongoing work extends the focus on local state actors in two directions. First, in *"Bureaucratic Quality and Local Industrial Development"* (with Muhammad Yasir Khan and S. K. Ritadhi), we study how much individual bureaucrats matter for local industrial development in India by exploiting the rotation of Indian Administrative Service officers across districts to separate the contribution of individual bureaucrats from local characteristics. We plan to explore what drives bureaucratic quality, and how development policy itself affects the role bureaucrats play in local development. Second, in joint work with Noah Braun, Paige Montrose, and Lauren Olson, we study how political representation shapes whose interests are reflected in state policy. We are constructing a new historical dataset on U.S. state-legislature representation by collecting legislative district descriptions from state constitutions, legislative acts, historical maps, election records, directories, and state blue books, and combining these sources with full-count census data to measure relative representation over time.

II. Economic Shocks and Local Labor Markets.

Economic shocks can reshape local labor markets and have uneven effects across workers, sectors, and places (Autor et al., 2013). Governments play an important role in mitigating the risk or redirecting employment and production through industrial or development policies, an increasingly important issue amid globalization, geopolitical tensions, and technological change. I study the dynamics of the local responses to economic shocks.

In *"Building Jobs: Employment Stabilization and Construction in China"*, I study how local governments in China use the construction sector to respond to negative labor market shocks and the longer-run implications of these responses. Politicians have incentives to stabilize employment, but short-run interventions may also generate longer-run distortions. Combining data from customs, city statistical yearbooks, government land transaction records, and government work reports, I exploit cross-city-year variation in exposure to China's mid-2010s export slowdown and use a shift-share instrument that combines changes in global trade outside China driven by recovery from the 2008 Financial Crisis with cities' initial export composition. I find that more exposed cities experience substantial manufacturing employment losses followed by increases in construction employment, the only sector experiencing an employment increase after the shocks. This construction response is stronger when city leaders face stronger career incentives and where labor unrest increases more sharply. Similar construction responses arise following automation shocks that displace manufacturing workers. Local governments facilitate this adjustment through land sales that stimulate real estate and infrastructure construction. While this response partially offsets employment losses in the short run, suggestive evidence points to greater real-estate risk in the longer run. The paper shows how political incentives shape local adjustment to economic shocks and highlights a tradeoff between short-run employment stabilization and longer-run economic risk.

In “*Geopolitical Tensions and Economic Opportunity: Evidence from Japan*” (with Weizheng Lai), we examine a different source of economic shocks from geopolitical forces. We study U.S. military procurement in Japan during the Korean War, a large demand shock generated by conflict outside Japan. Using newly digitized historical data, we construct a shift-share measure of Japan’s prefectures’ exposure to military procurement based on pre-war industrial specialization and procurement intensity across industries, and trace its effects using an event-study design. We find that procurement increased employment, induced labor relocation, and raised labor productivity in more exposed prefectures. We also find suggestive evidence that procurement reduced electoral support for parties opposed to Japanese rearmament and military alliance. These results show how geopolitical shocks can create new economic opportunities in third countries and how the resulting economic gains may also shape domestic political outcomes.

III. Institutional Change and Individual Behavior.

A third strand of my research studies how individuals interact with institutions. In “*Migrant Integration and Social Stability: Evidence from China*” (with Weizheng Lai), we study whether reducing institutional barriers to migrant integration affects their participation in labor unrest. The question is policy relevant as contemporary policy discourse often blames immigrants for bringing social unrest, fueling support for exclusionary immigration policies. We study China’s 2014 hukou reform, which relaxed barriers to obtaining local household registration in cities below a population threshold while maintaining stricter restrictions in larger cities. Using this population rule, we implement a difference-in-discontinuity design that compares changes in labor unrest across cities around the three-million-population cutoff before and after the reform. We find that reducing barriers to migrant integration significantly decreases labor unrest and we identify a key mechanism: the reform increased migrants’ settlement intentions, thereby reducing their incentives to engage in unrest in order to avoid retaliation and secure permanent settlement opportunities.

References

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